

COMPANION TO THE BOOK

Color Gallery

Where the seeds are, when they are ready and what they look like, for all 30 plants in *Seed Saving for the Backyard Gardener*.

Emma Stone

START HERE

How to Use This Gallery

Keep it open on your phone in the garden, next to the book.

Each plant has one page that answers three questions:

- **Where are the seeds?** The arrow shows which part of the plant to look at.
- **Is it ready?** The sign to watch for, the same one as in Table 6 of the book.
- **What do they look like?** The seeds close up, so you know what you are keeping.

> Most images are real photographs from many gardeners and collections, so a few show a plant before it is ready. The text says so when that happens. **Seven images are AI-generated** and marked on the image. Seed color and size change with the variety, so use these as a guide, and the steps in the book for the details.

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Tomato

Solanum lycopersicum

Steps in the book
page 34



Photo: Ramesh NG, CC BY-SA 2.0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds sit in pockets of jelly around the center of the fruit.

Is it ready?

Fruit fully ripe, even a little past eating stage.

This fruit shows the seeds. For seed, leave yours on the vine a little longer.



Photo: seed library, public domain.

What do they look like?

Washed tomato seeds drying on a plate. They are small, flat and pale tan.

Bean

Phaseolus vulgaris

Steps in the book
page 36



Photo: Roger Culos, CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The beans line up inside the pod. These pods have dried on the plant.

Is it ready?

Pods tan, dry and papery; seeds rattle.



Photo: Rasbak, CC BY-SA 3.0.

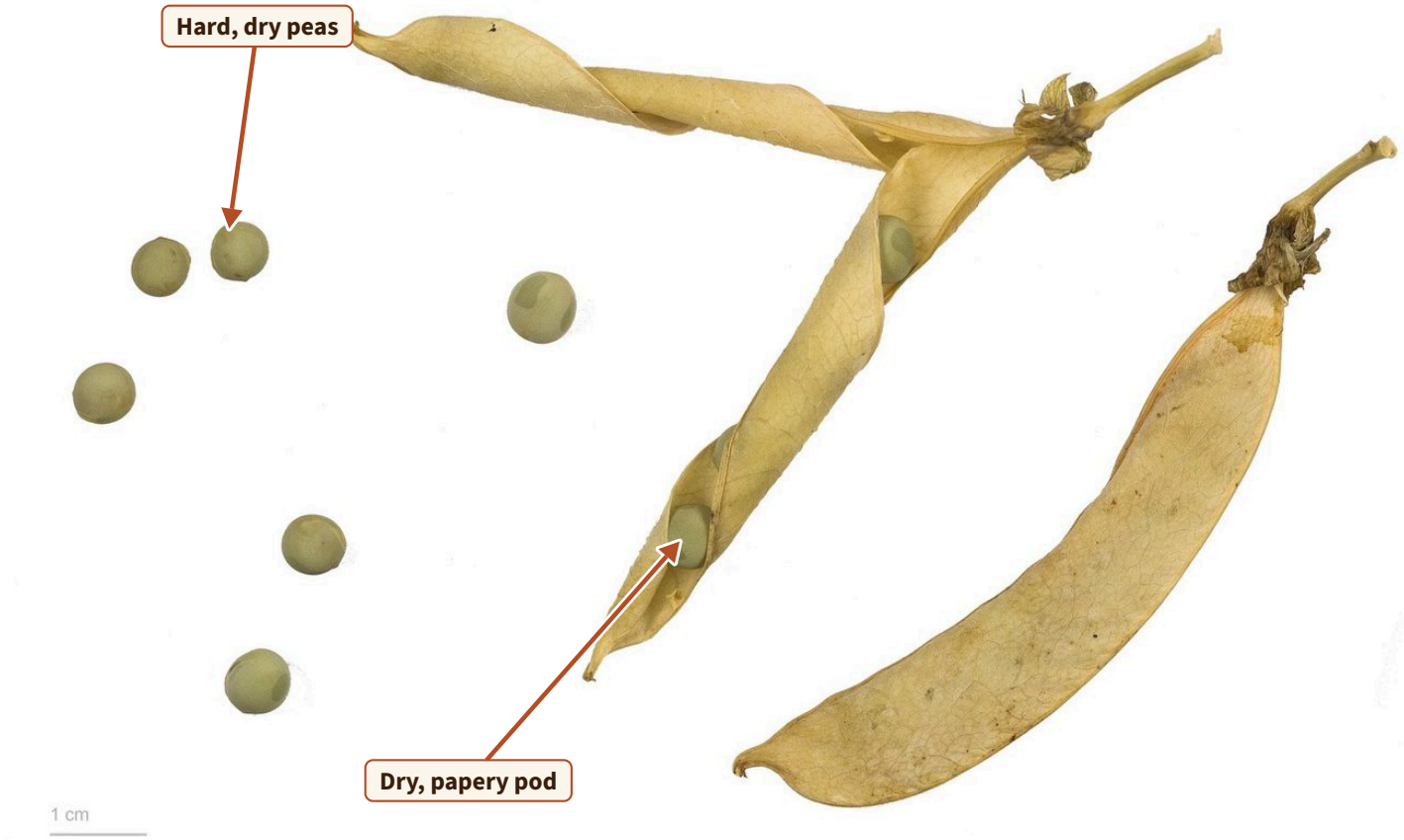
What do they look like?

Smooth and kidney-shaped. Color and pattern change with the variety. These are a brown Dutch heirloom.

Pea

Pisum sativum

Steps in the book
page 38



Where are the seeds?

The peas grow in a row inside the pod. Two are still in the split pod at the center of the photo.

Is it ready?

Pods tan, dry and papery; seeds rattle.

What do they look like?

Hard and round, or wrinkled, depending on the variety.

Photo: Roger Culos, CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.

Lettuce

Lactuca sativa

Steps in the book
page 40



Photo: graibeard, CC BY-SA 2.0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

Each flower head makes its own seeds, so one stalk shows every stage at once.

Is it ready?

Flower heads turn into white, fluffy tufts.



Photo: Tracey Slotta @ USDA-NRCS PLANTS Database, public domain.

What do they look like?

Thin, ribbed and pointed, in a close-up with a 2 mm scale bar. Color changes with the variety.

Pepper

Capsicum annuum

Steps in the book
page 42



Photo: Paul Goyette, CC BY-SA 2.0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds grow on the pale core just under the stem.

Is it ready?

Fruit reaches full ripe color and begins to soften.



Photo: Philmarin, CC BY-SA 3.0.

What do they look like?

Flat, round and pale yellow, in the palm of a hand for size.

Eggplant

Solanum melongena

Steps in the book
page 44

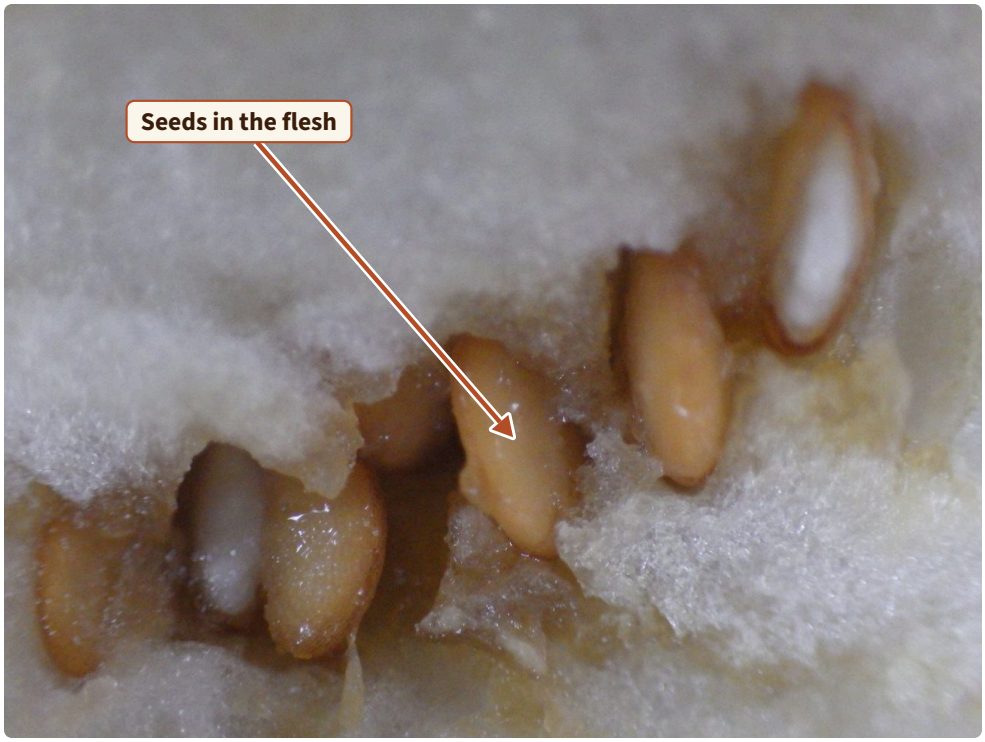


Photo: Schlaghecken Josef, CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds are scattered through the soft flesh. This is a close-up.

Is it ready?

Skin dull, hard and brown or yellow, well past eating stage.

This fruit was cut before seed stage. Yours should go well past eating stage.



Photo: Arn, CC BY-SA 4.0.

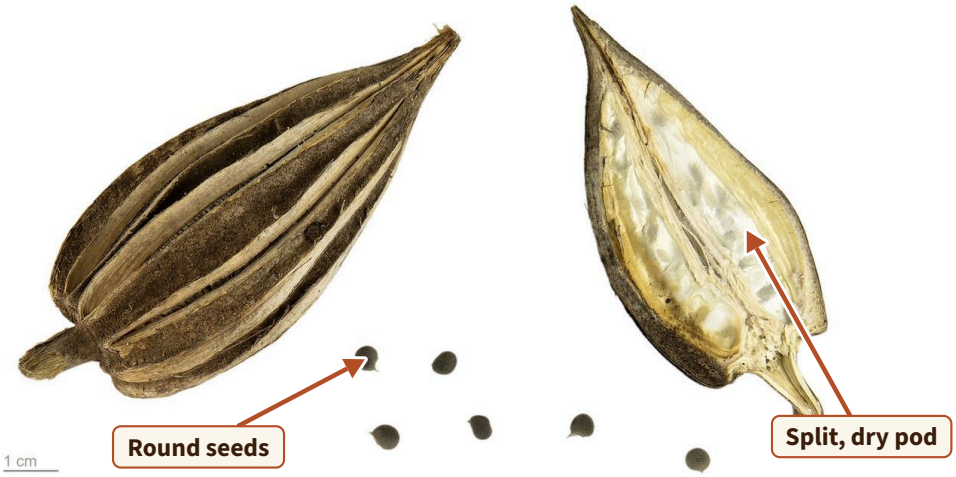
What do they look like?

Small, flat and tan, once washed out of the flesh.

Okra

Abelmoschus esculentus

Steps in the book
page 46



Where are the seeds?

The seeds grow in rows along the inside of the pod, between the ridges.

Is it ready?

Pods brown, dry and starting to split.

Photo: Roger Culos, CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Round and dark with a rough coat, in a close-up on graph paper.

Photo: GBoutruche, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Basil

Ocimum basilicum

Steps in the book
page 48



Where are the seeds?

The seeds sit in small cups along the flower spike.

Is it ready?

Flower spikes or heads brown and dry.

Photo: Emmanuel Douzery, CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Tiny and black, on graph paper for size.

Photo: Zenon Sych, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Dill

Anethum graveolens

Steps in the book
page 50



AI-generated image, not a photograph of a real plant. Details in the credits.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds form at the tips of the flat flower head, called an umbel.

Is it ready?

Flower spikes or heads brown and dry.



Photo: Arto Alanenpää, CC BY-SA 3.0.

What do they look like?

Flat and oval, with dark ribs and a pale edge.

Sunflower

Helianthus annuus

Steps in the book
page 52



Where are the seeds?

The seeds fill the face of the head, each one under a small floret.

Is it ready?

Back of head yellow-brown, head droops, seeds plump.

Photo: kewl, CC BY 2.0, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Plump and pointed at one end. These have black hulls; color changes with the variety.

Photo: Amada44, CC BY 3.0.

Marigold

Tagetes spp.

Steps in the book
page 54



Where are the seeds?

The seeds stand packed inside the papery base of the flower head.

Is it ready?

Flower head dry, base or stem below it brown.

What do they look like?

Long and thin, black at one end and pale at the other.

Photo: Roger Culos, CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.

Zinnia

Zinnia elegans

Steps in the book
page 56



AI-generated image, not a photograph of a real plant. Details in the credits.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds sit at the base of the dry petals, in the center of the head.

Is it ready?

Flower head dry, base or stem below it brown.



Photo: Media Mike Hazard, CC BY 2.0.

What do they look like?

Flat and shaped like small arrowheads. Shown here by the bucketful.

Cucumber

Cucumis sativus

Steps in the book
page 60



AI-generated image, not a photograph of a real plant. Details in the credits.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds are inside the fruit, down the center. A seed cucumber looks nothing like one you would eat.

Is it ready?

Fruit yellow to brown and soft, weeks past eating stage.



Photo: Fumikas Sagisavas, CC0.

What do they look like?

Flat, smooth, narrow ovals, pale tan.

Summer Squash and Zucchini

Cucurbita pepo

Steps in the book
page 62



AI-generated image, not a photograph of a real plant. Details in the credits.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds run down the center of the fruit. Eating-stage zucchini seeds are too soft to save.

Is it ready?

Rind hard; then cure 3 weeks indoors.



Photo: Schlaghecken Josef, CC BY-SA 4.0.

What do they look like?

Large, flat, cream-colored ovals with a raised edge.

Winter Squash and Pumpkin

Cucurbita maxima, C. moschata, C. pepo

Steps in the book
page 64



Where are the seeds?

The seeds hang in the stringy pulp at the center of the fruit.

Is it ready?

Fully mature; cure 3 weeks or more.

Photo: Namayasai LLP, CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Flat and cream-colored with a thick rim. Shape and size change with the species.

Photo: Dmitry Makeev, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Melon

Cucumis melo

Steps in the book
page 66

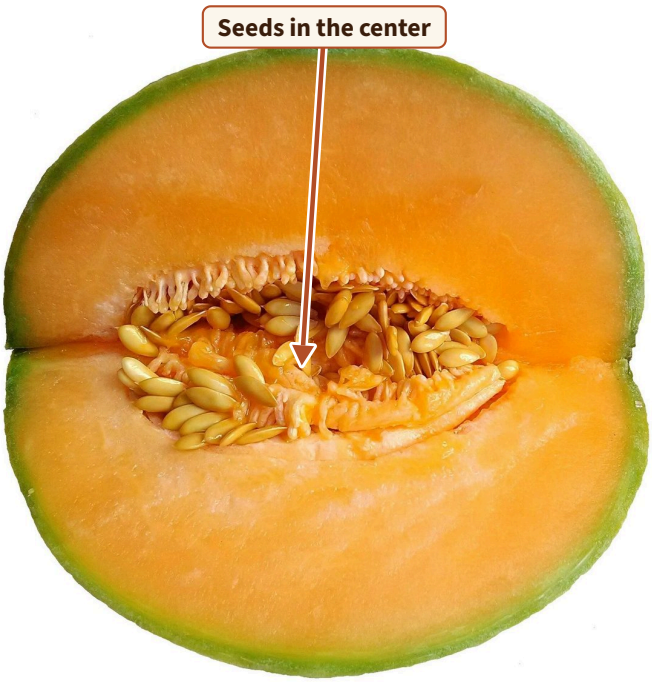


Photo: Filo gèn', CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds fill the hollow at the center of the fruit.

Is it ready?

Ripe to eat.

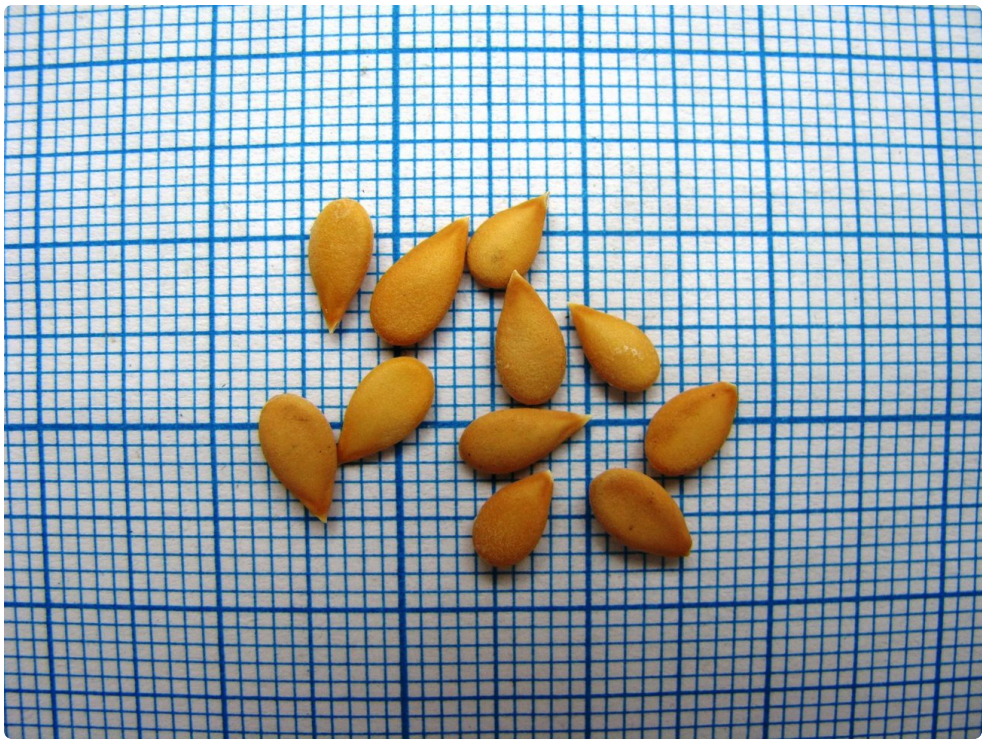


Photo: Zenon Sych, CC BY-SA 4.0.

What do they look like?

Pointed ovals, tan, on graph paper for size.

Watermelon

Citrullus lanatus

Steps in the book
page 68

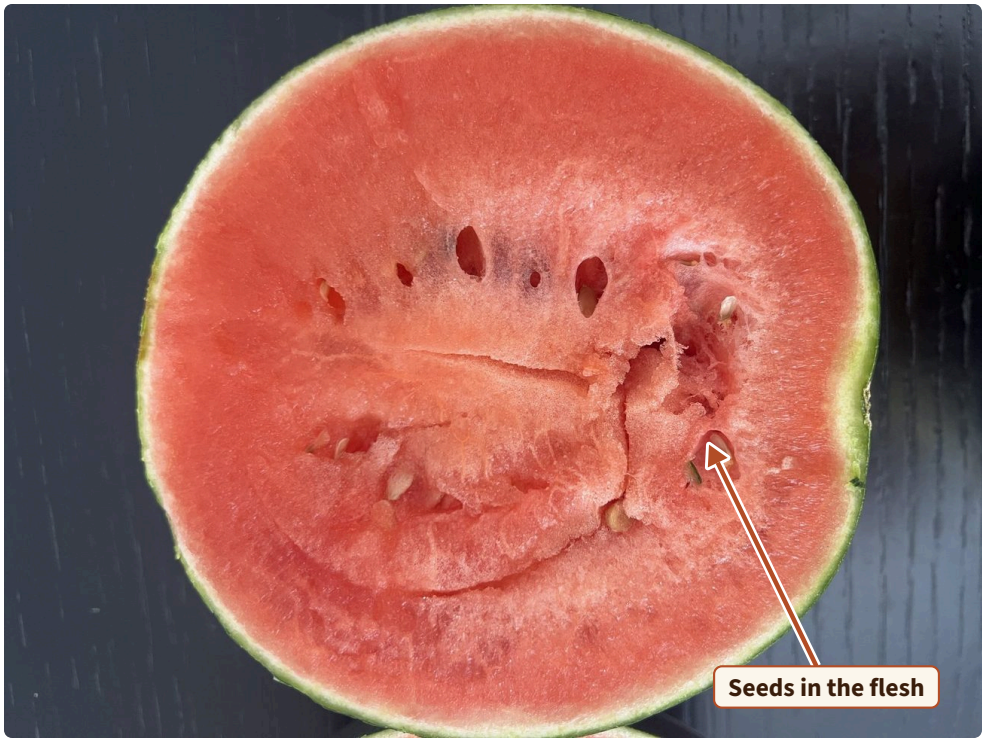


Photo: HaJunkiyada, CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds are spread through the red flesh, not gathered in a hollow.

Is it ready?

Ripe to eat.



Photo: Salil Kumar Mukherjee, CC BY-SA 4.0.

What do they look like?

Dark and full-colored. Pale or white seeds are immature.

Tomatillo

Physalis philadelphica

Steps in the book
page 70



Photo: Ikeryolo16, CC0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

Many tiny seeds are spread through the flesh.

Is it ready?

Husk dry and papery, fruit fills or splits it.

This fruit is cut before seed stage. Wait for the dry husk.



Photo: Roger Culos, CC BY-SA 3.0.

What do they look like?

Dry husks with the shriveled fruit and its seeds inside. Loose seeds are tiny, flat and pale.

Radish

Raphanus sativus

Steps in the book
page 72



Photo: Leo Michels, public domain, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds grow inside plump pods on the flowering stalk, not in the root.

Is it ready?

Most pods tan and dry.

These pods are still green: not ready yet.



Photo: Hugowolf at English Wikipedia, CC BY 3.0.

What do they look like?

Rounded, reddish brown and uneven, with a scale in millimeters.

Arugula

Eruca sativa

Steps in the book
page 74



Where are the seeds?

The seeds grow in pods that hug the stalk.

Is it ready?

Most pods tan and dry.

These pods are still green: not ready yet.

Photo: Philippe Marin, CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Tiny, round and brown, next to a ruler in centimeters.

Photo: Алексей Кабанов, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Cilantro

Coriandrum sativum

Steps in the book
page 76



Where are the seeds?

The round seeds form in small clusters at the tips of the stems.

Is it ready?

Flower spikes or heads brown and dry.

Photo: Forest and Kim Starr, CC BY 3.0 US, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Round, ribbed and tan. These are the coriander seeds you buy as a spice.

Photo: Sanjay Acharya, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Chives

Allium schoenoprasum

Steps in the book
page 78



Where are the seeds?

The seeds form in small capsules in the round flower heads.

Is it ready?

Capsules split and show black seed.

Photo: Noebse, public domain, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Shiny and black, showing in the split capsules.

Photo: WingkLEE, public domain.

Carrot

Daucus carota

Steps in the book
page 82



Where are the seeds?

The seeds grow on the flower head, in the plant's second year. This head is wild carrot, the same species with the same nest shape.

Is it ready?

Seed head brown and curled inward like a nest.

This head is still green: not ready yet.

Photo: Agnes Monkelbaan, CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Small, ribbed ovals with fine spines, on a dime for size.

Photo: John Alan Elson, CC BY-SA 3.0.

Beet and Swiss Chard

Beta vulgaris

Steps in the book
page 85



Where are the seeds?

The seed clusters form all along the tall stalks, in the plant's second year.

Is it ready?

Lowest seed clusters brown and hard.

These stalks are still green: not ready yet.

Photo: Shi Annan, CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Rough, corky clusters, brown, in a small bowl. Each cluster holds several seeds.

Photo: Downtowngal, CC BY-SA 3.0.

Onion

Allium cepa

Steps in the book
page 87



Photo: Humoyun Mehridinov, CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds form in small capsules on the round flower head, in the plant's second year.

Is it ready?

Capsules open and show black seed.



Photo: Hamza DK, CC BY-SA 4.0.

What do they look like?

Black and angular, shown in the hand with some pale chaff still mixed in.

Kale and Collards

Brassica oleracea

Steps in the book
page 89



Photo: Rasbak, CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds grow in long, thin pods, in the plant's second year. These pods are on broccoli, the same species.

Is it ready?

Most pods tan and dry.

These pods are still green: not ready yet.



Photo: Salicyna, CC BY-SA 4.0.

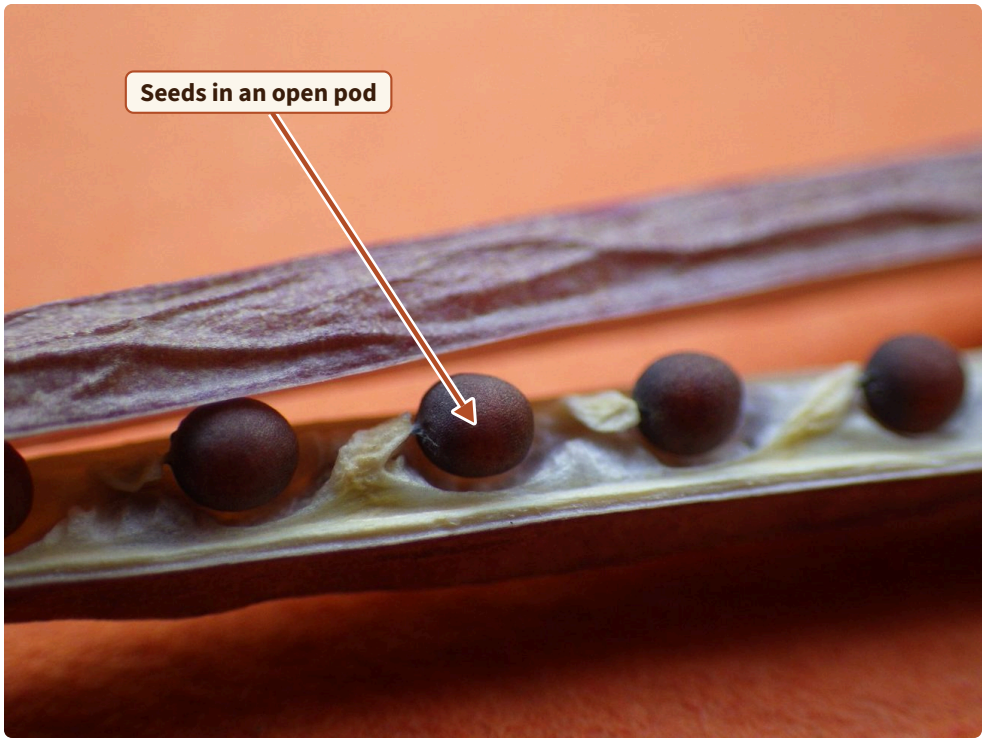
What do they look like?

Round and dark brown, on a millimeter grid. The shriveled pieces are debris and duds.

Cabbage and Broccoli

Brassica oleracea

Steps in the book
page 91



Where are the seeds?

The seeds line up inside long pods on the flower stalk. This is a cabbage pod split open.

Is it ready?

Most pods tan and dry.

This pod is not dry yet. It was opened to show the seeds.

Photo: Schlaghecken Josef, CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.



What do they look like?

Small, round and nearly black. These are broccoli seeds with their dry pods.

Photo: Craig Dietrich from Los Angeles, CC BY 2.0.

Corn

Zea mays

Steps in the book
page 93



Photo: Huw Williams (Huwmanbeing), public domain, arrows added.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds are the kernels on the ear.

Is it ready?

Husks brown and dry, kernels hard.



Photo: Rasbak, CC BY-SA 3.0.

What do they look like?

Hard, wedge-shaped kernels. Color changes with the variety.

Spinach

Spinacia oleracea

Steps in the book
page 95



AI-generated image, not a photograph of a real plant. Details in the credits.

Where are the seeds?

The seeds form in clusters along the stems of the female plants.

Is it ready?

Lowest seed clusters brown and hard.



What do they look like?

Round and tan on this variety. Some varieties have prickly seeds.

Photo: Amada44, CC BY 3.0.

Parsley

Petroselinum crispum

Steps in the book
page 97



Where are the seeds?

The seeds form on flat, umbrella-shaped flower heads, in the plant's second year.

Is it ready?

Flower spikes or heads brown and dry.

AI-generated image, not a photograph of a real plant. Details in the credits.



What do they look like?

Small, ribbed and curved, next to a scale in millimeters.

Photo: Jacopo Werther, CC BY-SA 4.0.

EXTRA

Male and Female Flowers

Squash and cucumber plants carry both kinds of flower. Spinach carries each kind on a separate plant.



Squash, female

A small fruit sits right behind the flower.

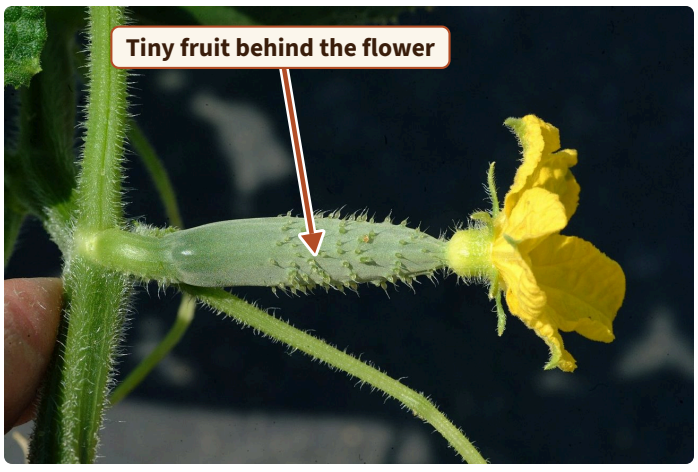
Photo: AswiniKP(Aswini Kumar P), CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.



Squash, male

A plain stem and no fruit behind the flower.

Photo: AswiniKP(Aswini Kumar P), CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.



Cucumber, female

The same rule works: look behind the flower for a tiny cucumber.

Photo: Schlaghecken Josef, CC BY-SA 4.0, arrows added.

How to use this

Look behind the petals. A tiny fruit means female. Hand-pollinating and bagging are explained in the book.

EXTRA

Spinach Flowers

After flowering, male plants turn yellow and die back. Leave them until the females have set seed.



Female plant

The flowers sit tight against the stem. This is the plant that makes the seed.

Photo: Rasbak, CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.



Male plant

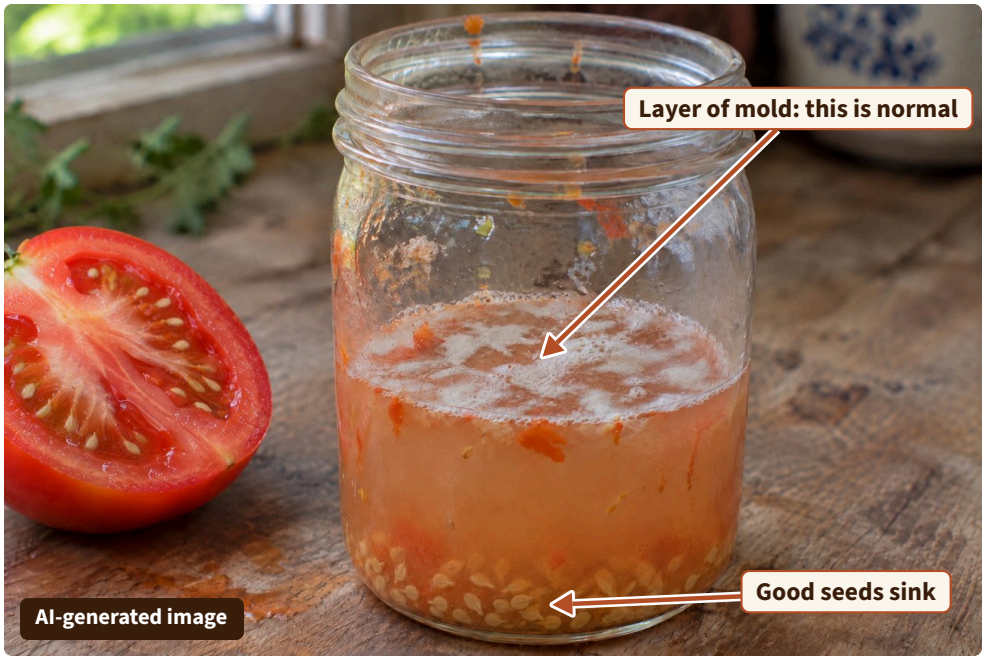
Small flowers in clusters at the top of the stem make the pollen.

Photo: Rasbak, CC BY-SA 3.0, arrows added.

EXTRA

The Process in Color

Two steps the black-and-white drawings in the book can only hint at.



Fermenting tomato seed

Seeds and gel in a jar with about the same amount of water. Mold on top is part of the process. The good seeds sink to the bottom.

Steps in the book: page 34

AI-generated image, not a photograph of a real plant. Details in the credits.



Cleaning dry seed

Pour everything through a kitchen sieve to catch stems and leaf bits.

Steps in the book: page 40

Photo: Ashley Basil, CC BY 2.0.

Image Credits

AI-generated images. Seven images were generated with AI and are marked on the image: the seed plants of dill, zinnia, cucumber, zucchini, spinach and parsley, and the tomato fermentation jar. They illustrate what the book describes. They are not photographs of real plants.

Photographs. All other images are real photographs under the open licenses below. The authors do not endorse this book or its use of their work. Images marked with a CC BY-SA license remain under that license, including the versions with arrows and labels. Titles link to the source pages.

Image	Author	License	Changes
Eruca sativa seeds	Алексей Кабанов	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
Eruca sativa f	Philippe Marin	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
Ocimum basilicum Васильки справжні - насіння	Zenon Sych	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
Ocimum basilicum desiccated 51452016 01 03	Emmanuel Douzery	CC BY-SA 4.0	arrows and labels added
Phaseolus vulgaris MHNT.BOT.2016.24.73	Roger Culos	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
Bruine boon Noordhollandse Bruine (Phaseolus vulgaris)	Rasbak	CC BY-SA 3.0	resized
Flowering Chard, Villa Borg	Shi Annan	CC BY-SA 4.0	rotated, arrows and labels added
Beet seeds	Downtowngal	CC BY-SA 3.0	resized
Kopfkohl Schote mit Samen an der Scheidewand-Josef Schlaghecken	Schlaghecken Josef	CC BY-SA 4.0	arrows and labels added
Broccoli Seeds at Bonsallo Avenue Urban Garden - Los Angeles	Craig Dietrich from Los Angeles	CC BY 2.0	resized
Carrotdime	John Alan Elson	CC BY-SA 3.0	resized
Wilde peen (Daucus carota). 06-09-2023. (actm.) 03	Agnes Monkelbaan	CC BY-SA 4.0	arrows and labels added
Chives small three-valved capsule with seeds	Noebse	public domain	arrows and labels added
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Starr-081031-0408-Coriandrum sativum-fruit-Makawao-Maui (24900408386)	Forest and Kim Starr	CC BY 3.0 US	arrows and labels added
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Zea mays seeds closeup	Rasbak	CC BY-SA 3.0	resized
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Auberginen Samenbildung in der Frucht-Josef Schlaghecken	Schlaghecken Josef	CC BY-SA 4.0	arrows and labels added
Aubergines graines	Arn	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
Broccoli siliques, hauwen (1)	Rasbak	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
Brassica oleracea var. sabellica Scarlet 2022-08-25 9124	Salicyna	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
LettuceSeedHead-7982	graibeard	CC BY-SA 2.0	arrows and labels added
Lactuca sativa seeds	Tracey Slotta @ USDA-NRCS PLANTS Database	public domain	resized
Tagetes patula MHNT.BOT.2007.43.30	Roger Culos	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
Cucumis melo on white background	Filo gèn'	CC BY-SA 4.0	arrows and labels added
Cucumis melo - Диня - Насіння - Сорт з Ізраїлю	Zenon Sych	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
Abelmoschus esculentus f 12	GBoutruche	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
Abelmoschus esculentus MHNT.BOT.2024.31.22	Roger Culos	CC BY-SA 4.0	arrows and labels added
Onion seed	Hamza DK	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
Onion seed head in Tashkent botanical garden	Humoyun Mehridinov	CC BY-SA 4.0	arrows and labels added
Petroselinum crispum seeds	Jacopo Werther	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
Pisum sativum MHNT.BOT.2010.12.9	Roger Culos	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
Bell pepper cut apart	Paul Goyette	CC BY-SA 2.0	arrows and labels added

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Spinach seeds round	Amada44	CC BY 3.0	resized
Spinacia oleracea female flowers, spinazie vrouwelijke bloemen	Rasbak	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
Spinacia oleracea male flowers, spinazie mannelijke bloemen	Rasbak	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
Cucurbita maxima female flower	AswiniKP(Aswini Kumar P)	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
CucurbitaMaxima male flower	AswiniKP(Aswini Kumar P)	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
Zucchini Samen der Sorte Ambassador-Josef Schlaghecken	Schlaghecken Josef	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
Seed head: when the party's over	kewl	CC BY 2.0	arrows and labels added
Black Helianthus annuus seeds 2	Amada44	CC BY 3.0	resized
Physalis Philadelphica open view	Ikeryolo16	CC0	arrows and labels added
Physalis ixocarpa MHNT.BOT.2008.1.52	Roger Culos	CC BY-SA 3.0	resized
Tomato - Cross section view	Ramesh NG	CC BY-SA 2.0	arrows and labels added
Tomato saving seed	seed library	public domain	rotated, resized
Watermelon Seeds	Salil Kumar Mukherjee	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
Liat Portal for Foodie Disorder - Watermelon Cross Section	HaJunkiyada	CC BY-SA 4.0	arrows and labels added
Kabocha Cut Open 29September2005	Namayasai LLP	CC BY-SA 3.0	arrows and labels added
Pumpkin seed. img 016	Dmitry Makeev	CC BY-SA 4.0	resized
DSC05956 Zinnia seeds	Media Mike Hazard	CC BY 2.0	resized